

ANIME: Source Sets the Audience Floor — Artometrics

ANIME: Source Sets the Audience Floor

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Why does one anime reach more than a million fans while another, often just as well made, reaches a few thousand? A MyAnimeList archive of 13,631 titles, running from 1917 theatrical shorts to an early-2019 snapshot, points first to a decision made before any animator is hired: where the story comes from.

On television, light-novel adaptations draw a median of 153,184 platform members. Manga adaptations draw 37,500 and original series 4,738, which puts light novels about 32 times ahead of originals. Quality follows a different pattern. Only 4.6% of originals and 0.5% of game adaptations score 8.0 or higher, compared with 17.0% of manga adap-

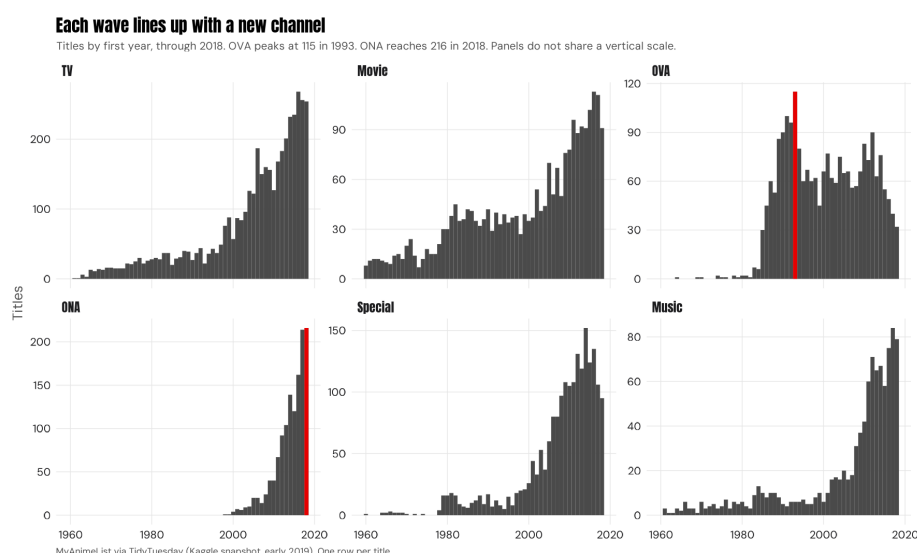
tations. Across all scored titles, a title's score and its audience move closely together, with a rank correlation of 0.74. Every comparison below is measured against the overall median score of 6.38.

This report reads the archive as the record of a production system, not a list of favorites. In that system, a production committee (seisaku iinkai) of publishers, broadcasters, music labels, and merchandisers pools the budget and splits copyright in proportion to each member's investment. The animation studio is typically a contracted manufacturer that doesn't own the IP (Hernández Hernández, 2018, §4.3; Mihara, 2018). The figures here are observed fan behavior on one platform. They show which projects found audiences, not which ones made money.

RESEARCH QUESTION

Which decisions made before production (format, source material, studio, and whether to make a sequel) are associated with a title's reach and fan rating, and where does the platform's popularity record miss strong work?

Each format wave lines up with a new distribution channel



Each wave lines up with a new channel. Direct-to-video output peaked at 115 titles in 1993, and web-first releases grew more than fivefold between 2009 and 2018.

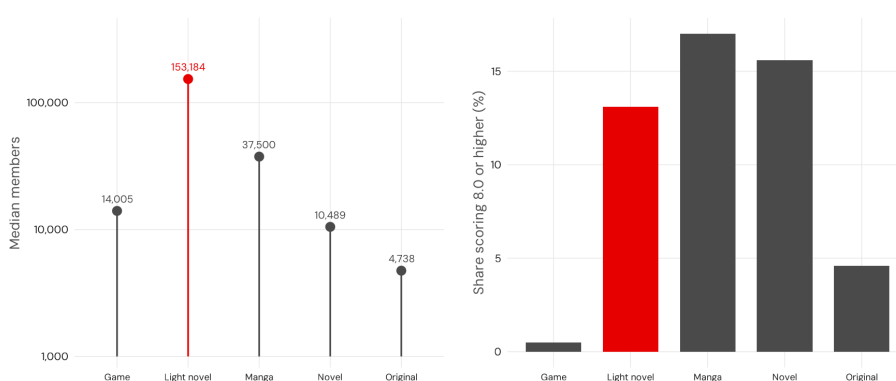
Anime output is not one growth curve. It's a series of format waves, and each wave lines up with a new channel. Theatrical film dominates the early catalog. Original video animation (OVA), sold directly on tape and disc, ran at roughly 100 titles a year from 1990 to 1993 and peaked at 115 in 1993. Television then became the core of the catalog, with 4,260 TV titles in the archive. Original net animation (ONA), made for web distribution first, grew from 40 titles in 2009 to 104 in 2013 and 216 in 2018, for 1,321 in total.

The archive records release format, not financing. Reading these waves as responses to new distribution channels is our editorial frame, not a measured finding, and the data can't show who paid for each wave. The context literature documents one wave directly: starting with Tet-suwan Atom (1963), TV anime was tied to sponsor merchandising (Steinberg, 2012).

Source material sets the audience floor

Light novels set the audience floor. Manga produces more 8.0s.

Scored television only (n = 4,240 of 4,260 TV titles). Left axis is a log scale.



MyAnimeList via TidyTuesday (Kaggle snapshot, early 2019). One row per title.

Light-novel adaptations reach the largest audiences, but manga adaptations produce top-rated shows most often (scored TV titles, n = 4,240 of 4,260).

Source (TV)	Ti-tles	Median score	Median mem-bers	Share scoring 8.0+
Light nov-el	283	7.35	153,184	13.1%
Manga	1,232	7.29	37,500	17.0%
Novel	122	7.13	10,489	15.6%
Original	1,012	6.63	4,738	4.6%

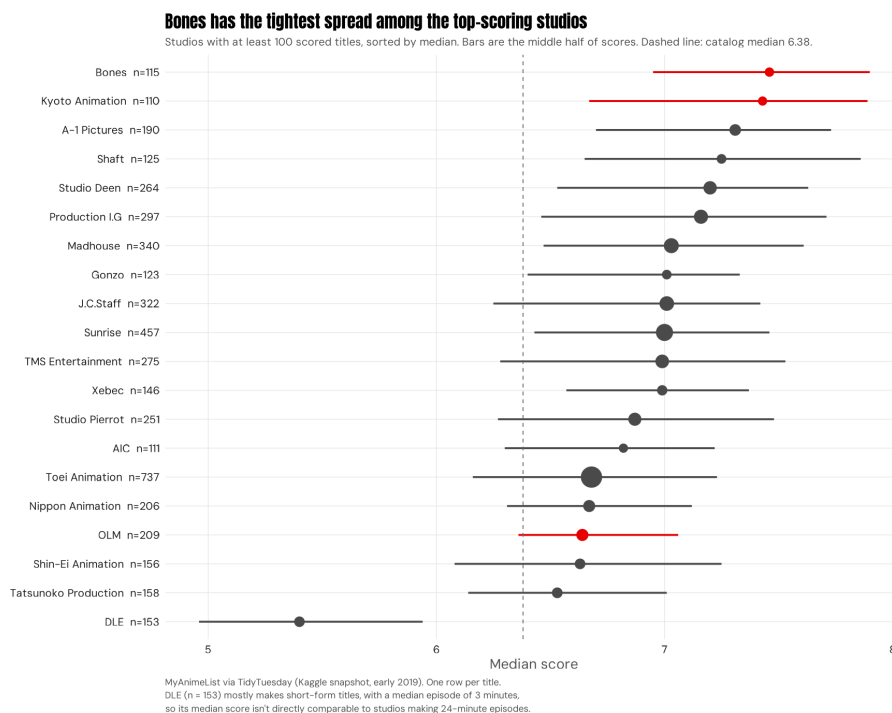
Source (TV)	Ti-tles	Median score	Median mem-bers	Share scoring 8.0+
Game	210	6.63	14,005	0.5%

The source of a story, its gensaku, is the biggest single dividing line in the TV catalog. Light-novel adaptations have the highest median score (7.35) and by far the largest median audience. They reach about four times as many members as manga adaptations and about 32 times as many as originals. Manga adaptations are close behind on score (7.29), and they produce the highest share of top-rated shows, at 17.0% scoring 8.0 or higher (210 of 1,232).

The mechanism is the media mix. A story is built across print, animation, music, and merchandise at once (Steinberg, 2012). On our reading, a published book also serves as a live test of demand before a committee commits money to animation. This is selection, not proof that adapting a book lowers risk. Committees adapt titles that already have readers, so some of that audience is arriving with the book.

Originals face the opposite problem. Their median score is 6.63, and only 4.6% reach 8.0 or higher. With no print run to test demand first, an original has to prove itself on air. Game adaptations are the weakest group by fan rating. Their median is 6.63, and only 0.5% score 8.0 or higher, which works out to one title in 210 (IDOLiSH7, 2018). For a committee, one practical reading is that a game adaptation is better budgeted as part of the game's marketing than as the start of a stand-alone animated franchise. That reading is an editorial frame, not a result the file measures.

Consistency is a studio trait



Across the 20 largest studios, medians run from 7.46 to 5.40. Bones has the tightest spread among the top scorers, and OLM is the most consistent overall, at a lower level. DLE (n = 153) mostly makes short-form titles, with a median episode of 3 minutes, so its median score isn't directly comparable to studios making 24-minute episodes.

In a system where the committee owns the project, the animation studio is usually the prime contractor (motouke), and much of the drawing is subcontracted (shitauke) to other studios and freelancers (Hanzawa, 2004). Inside a studio, production managers (seisaku shinkou) coordinate the work but depend on key creatives, whose drawing skill routinely gives them the upper hand (Morisawa, 2015). That makes a studio's typical output a better guide to what a commission will deliver than its single biggest hit.

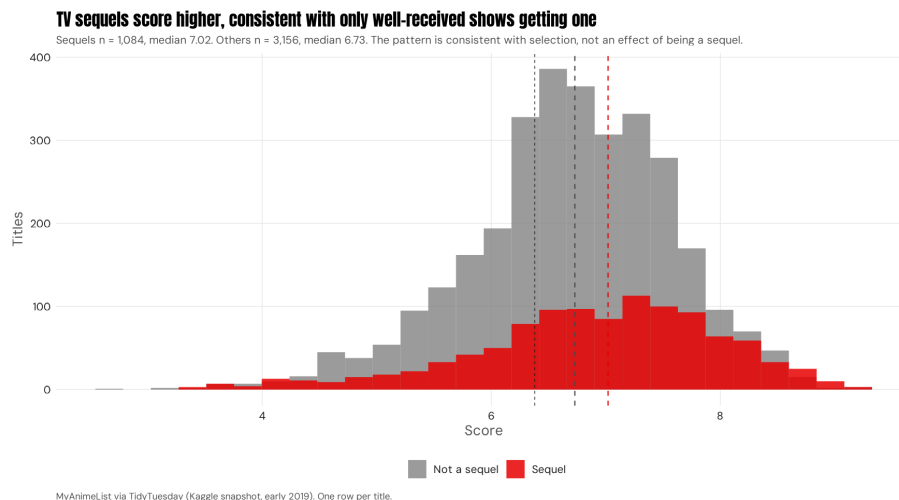
Bones has 115 titles, a median of 7.46, an interquartile range (IQR, the spread of the middle half of its scores) of 0.95, and 23.5% of its titles scoring 8.0 or higher, the tightest spread among the top-scoring studios (only 7th-tightest of all 20). Kyoto Animation's 110 titles have a median of 7.43 and an IQR of 1.22. Kyoto Animation employs mostly salaried in-house staff and trains animators through its own school, which is unusual in an industry built on subcontracting (Creamer, 2015; Moore, 2017; Kyoto Animation training school). OLM is the counterexample

that makes the point. Its 209 titles have a median of only 6.64, but its IQR of 0.70 is the tightest of any studio with 100 or more titles. It delivers a predictable product at a modest level.

For anyone choosing a prime contractor, the decision metric is a studio's median and spread, not its best-known title. Across the 20 studios with 100 or more scored titles, median scores run from 7.46 (Bones) down to 5.40 (DLE). DLE (n = 153) mostly makes short-form titles, with a median episode of 3 minutes, so its median score isn't directly comparable to studios making 24-minute episodes. Bones and OLM have a 24-minute median episode. The largest studio, Toei (737 titles), sits near the bottom of the table at 6.68. Of those titles, 2.8% score 8.0 or higher (21 of 737).

Studio	n	Median	Middle 50%	IQR	Share 8.0+
Bones	115	7.46	6.95–7.90	0.95	23.5%
Kyoto Animation	110	7.43	6.67–7.89	1.22	20.9%
A-1 Pictures	190	7.31	6.70–7.73	1.03	14.7%
Shaft	125	7.25	6.65–7.86	1.21	16.8%
Studio Deen	264	7.20	6.53–7.63	1.10	8.3%
Production I.G	297	7.16	6.46–7.71	1.25	13.5%
Madhouse	340	7.03	6.47–7.61	1.15	15.9%
Gonzo	123	7.01	6.40–7.33	0.93	2.4%
J.C.Staff	322	7.01	6.25–7.42	1.17	7.5%
Sunrise	457	7.00	6.43–7.46	1.03	6.8%
TMS Entertainment	275	6.99	6.28–7.53	1.26	10.2%
Xebec	146	6.99	6.57–7.37	0.80	2.1%
Studio Pierrot	251	6.87	6.27–7.48	1.21	6.0%
AIC	111	6.82	6.30–7.22	0.93	0.9%
Toei Animation	737	6.68	6.16–7.23	1.07	2.8%
Nippon Animation	206	6.67	6.31–7.12	0.81	3.4%
OLM	209	6.64	6.36–7.06	0.70	0.5%
Shin-Ei Animation	156	6.63	6.08–7.25	1.17	0.6%
Tatsunoko Production	158	6.53	6.14–7.01	0.86	3.8%
DLE	153	5.40	4.96–5.94	0.98	0.7%

Sequels score higher, consistent with only well-received shows getting one

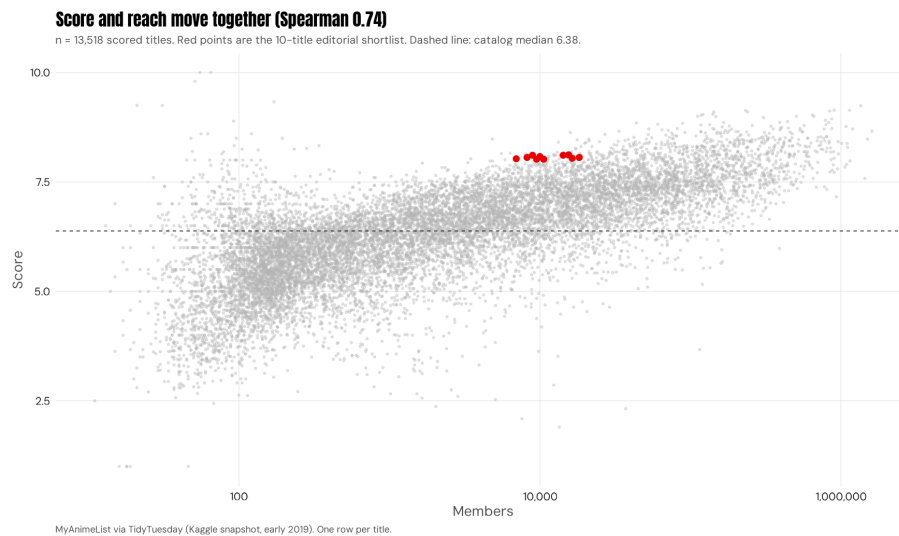


TV sequels score higher and draw larger audiences, consistent with only well-received shows getting a second season.

The 1,084 TV sequels in the archive have a median score of 7.02, and 14.7% of them score 8.0 or higher. The 3,156 TV titles that aren't sequels have a median of 6.73 and a rate of 5.9%. Sequels also draw more members at the median, 11,430 against 8,013.

The pattern is consistent with selection, not an effect of being a sequel. A committee only orders a second season of a show that did well, and the viewers who return for it already liked the first one. It also fits the shortlist count: 30 of the 43 high scorers with at least 1,000 ratings are sequels. For a buyer, a sequel's score says more about the strength of the property than about the sequel itself.

Popularity tracks quality, with a short list of exceptions



Across 13,518 scored titles, score and reach rise together (rank correlation 0.74). Only a handful of stand-alone, highly rated titles remain obscure.

Member counts are extremely skewed. A rank (Spearman) correlation gives 0.74, and correlating score with the log of member count gives 0.72. On this platform, well-rated titles are usually well watched.

The exceptions are rare and specific. Of 603 titles scoring 8.0 or higher, 78 sit beyond popularity rank 3,000. Requiring at least 1,000 user ratings cuts that to 43. Of the 43 titles with at least 1,000 ratings, 30 are sequels; only 10 TV series or films that aren't sequels remain.

The Buried Canon is an editorial shortlist, not a measured ranking: score of 8.0 or higher, popularity rank past 3,000, 1,000 or more ratings, TV or film, and no prequel, parent story, or full story on MyAnimeList.

Title	Year	Studio	Score	Popularity rank	Ratings
Ginga Nagareboshi Gin	1986	Toei Animation	8.12	3,292	7,030
Hanada Shounen-shi	2002	Madhouse	8.11	4,157	2,616
Kindaichi Shounen no Jikenbo	1997	Toei Animation	8.11	3,425	2,876
Omae Umasou da na (film)	2010	Ajia-Do	8.08	3,973	4,076

Title	Year	Studio	Score	Popularity rank	Ratings
Ginga Sengoku Gunyuuden Rai	1994	E&G Films	8.06	4,316	2,956
IDOLiSH7	2018	TROYCA	8.06	3,037	4,788
Hyouge Mono	2011	Bee Train	8.04	3,194	2,098
Igano Kabamaru	1983	Group TAC	8.03	4,602	2,816
Ie Naki Ko Remy	1996	Nippon Animation	8.02	3,866	4,793
Takarajima	1978	Madhouse	8.02	4,057	3,442

Four of these titles (Kindaichi, Omae Umasou da na, Ie Naki Ko Remy, Takarajima) have other versions on MyAnimeList, but none is a sequel. For a licensor, distributor, or restoration house, this is a short, checkable list of rated-but-unseen catalog. Whether any of it is available to license is outside this dataset.

LIMITATIONS

Coverage window. The data is a Kaggle snapshot of MyAnimeList taken in early 2019 and published through TidyTuesday on April 23, 2019. Nothing released after that is included, and 2019 itself is only partly covered, which is why the format series ends at 2018.

Platform audience. MyAnimeList is an English-language enthusiast site. Its scores reflect that audience's expectations. Kids titles (median 5.86, n = 2,158) and music titles (median 5.44, n = 1,510) score lowest, which more likely reflects a mismatch between audience and content than weak production. Thriller (7.50, n = 102), Mystery (7.27, n = 605), and Psychological (7.23, n = 279) score highest.

No commercial data. The file has no revenue, broadcast ratings, disc sales, box office, or merchandise figures. A low score doesn't mean a franchise lost money.

Selection, not causation. Source material, studio, and sequel status are all chosen with an eye to expected demand, so none of the gaps above should be read as the effect of that choice alone. The format chart lines each wave up with a channel. It does not show that the channel shaped what got made.

Deduplication. The source file repeats each title once per studio and genre (77,911 rows for 13,631 titles). All title-level figures here use one row per title.

CONCLUSION: Choose the source, judge the studio by its median, and read sequel scores as property scores

The archive doesn't show what makes anime good. It does show where the industry's early decisions leave a mark. Adapting a light novel or manga brings an audience that is already there, while an original has to find one. Studios differ clearly in their typical output, which is the better guide to a commission. Sequel scores mostly reflect the shows that earned them. Beyond those patterns lies a short list of strong titles the platform's audience never found. The next useful question is commercial. Matching these fan signals to revenue data would show whether the platform's audience floor is also a revenue floor.

Data, methods & sources

Data and method

The primary data is the MyAnimeList dataset published by TidyTuesday on April 23, 2019 (`tidy_anime.csv`), a Kaggle scrape of MyAnimeList by Tam Nguyen taken around February 2019. The file has 77,911 rows because it repeats each title once per studio and genre. We collapsed it to 13,631 unique titles (one row per animeID) dated 1917 to 2019. Studio statistics use one row per title and studio, and genre statistics use one row per title and genre. Scores, member counts, popularity ranks, rating counts, formats, sources, and related-title links are observed data. Medians, shares scoring 8.0 or higher, IQRs, and correlations are derived metrics. Quartiles use R's type-7 quantile. Displayed figures use round-half-up on the exact value, not R's `round()`.

Score comparisons on television use scored TV titles, $n = 4,240$ of 4,260. Titles with no score are excluded from score statistics (13,518 scored). The rank correlation of score and members is Spearman, $n = 13,518$. A title is a sequel when its related field lists a Prequel, a Parent story, or a Full story. The 1,000-rating minimum applies only to the shortlist cut, not to the catalog medians. The Buried Canon is an editorial shortlist built with the filters stated above. Known biases: the snapshot stops in

early 2019, the raters are an English-language enthusiast audience, and source, studio, and sequel are selected with demand in mind, so the gaps are associations. Reproduce the charts and tables with `npm run brief:anime` from the repository root. The script checks SHA-256 `5ea3a14492b5c559c728af0c7ec57b81c919d0efa4d381e54b0f7cde9934a1c2` on the raw file before it computes.

Sources

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EDITOR'S NOTE

This report was produced by the Artometrics editorial desk working with AI research, data, and design agents under human editorial direction. All figures were recomputed from the deduplicated source file and checked against a verified-numbers log before publication. The data and code are available from the site's Download menu.

— Artometrics Editorial Desk